se poochiye' (Why ask me, go and ask Rahul Gandhi). Lalu eventually waited for almost a month to seal the deal when he should have been out in the battlefield of Bihar.

The uneasy Rahul–Lalu equation summed up the Congress leader's limited world view. For Rahul, Lalu was the village idiot, not a potential ally to do business with. Rahul failed to realize that under the cloak of the clown ticked a very sharp political brain. I had met Lalu for the first time in the early 1990s—a meeting of an English-educated south Bombay boy with a rustic Bihari. Our interview was fixed for 11 o'clock. I arrived at 11 a.m., only to be told that Lalu had meant 11 p.m. We set up for the interview in his official residence, only to be told that it would take place not in the house but in the cowshed in order to broadcast the right 'effect'! The spitting, bellowing cowherd's send-up of elite politics was part reality and part highly strategic performance. Interview over, Lalu tried to teach me how to milk a cow. '*Tum angrezi logon ko yeh sab seekhna chahiye'* (You anglicized folk should learn how to do these things), he told me with barely concealed contempt at my failed attempts.

Lalu had built his political reputation as a saviour of the minorities by arresting Advani during the 1990 rath yatra. And the source of his political appeal lay beyond just Muslims and his fellow Yadavs. In 1995, when he scored a big win in Bihar, he invited me to a late-night celebration. The garden at the chief minister's bungalow had been converted into a song and dance soirée—the drink, too, was flowing. Sitting in a corner was an old man in a slightly torn shirt.

I went up to him and asked him what he was doing there. 'I am a street vendor. Laluji has given an open invitation to all of us to come and celebrate here tonight,' he told me. Then he said, tellingly, *'Pehle toh hum chief minister bangle ko bahar se bhi dekh nahi sakte thhe, aaj Laluji ne toh hamein izzat di'* (Earlier, we couldn't even see the chief minister's house, now Lalu has given us respect).

Yet, Laloo's drive for empowering backward castes quickly descended into a dark pit of corruption, criminality and family raj. I remember interviewing Rabri Devi the day she was sworn in as chief minister, with